

A Fool

(ഒരു മണ്ടൻ)

Here, in the ordinary wilderness of a home, the fool is born.

Like all young creatures, he arrives with an empty stomach and an open mouth. Hunger is his first language; trust, his second. A spoon is simply a spoon, and every hand that offers one must surely know what belongs inside him.

So, he eats.

His mother serves him certainty. His teachers carve truth into neat portions and set it down without garnish. His friends season their opinions with laughter, which makes them easier to swallow. Society lays out its usual banquet and calls it *the way things are*.

He never asks who cooked the meal.

Then a second child arrives, smaller and louder in its hungers, and his mother's strength begins to ebb in the quiet way houses absorb such things. No one marks the occasion. One afternoon the chair is simply empty, and he finds himself reaching for the stove.

Oil teaches before people do.

He burns his fingers learning what a mother's hands already knew, and calls the burns proof of something. People will later mistake this for independence. He never corrects them. It is easier to let a house believe its youngest has grown strong than to admit he was only ever left standing.

He grows, and his appetite grows strange with him.

Once a boy who picked at his plate, he now eats almost anything—beliefs, expectations, borrowed certainties. Conviction, he learns, is often disguise enough; if a thing is served with confidence, it hardly matters whether it nourishes.

Yet when his parents cook, something in him refuses.

Not the food. The receiving of it.

He would rather make a poor meal with his own hands than accept a good one from someone else's. There are hunger's pride mistakes for freedom, and this is one of them.

Somewhere in his schooling, something in the body quietly rearranges itself.

No doctor points to it. No mirror shows it. He only notices, one ordinary day, that the hunger has left him—not the food, which is still there, still warm, still his mother's best recipe placed in front of him like an apology, but the part of him that wants it.

They call it a phase. A distraction. Foolishness.

He has no better word for it either, so he lets it be called that, while it quietly eats him from the inside instead.

An empty stomach eventually negotiates with strange kitchens.

He drinks warmth out of bottles that promise borrowed courage. He breathes in smoke that softens the room's hard edges. And late at night, alone, in the privacy reserved for lonely creatures, he feeds himself something smaller and more secret—enough to convince the body it hasn't been entirely abandoned, never enough to convince the rest of him.

None of these meals satisfy. They only postpone the next hunger.

Still—

morning keeps arriving.

So does he.

Around this time he arrives at an elegant conclusion: he requires no one. People complicate the recipe. People leave, or worse, they season their love with conditions and call the bitterness maturity.

Very well, he thinks. I will eat alone.

For a while, this feeds him almost as well as food itself—right up until someone arrives and leaves another room in the house empty.

Afterwards,

the hunger returns.

This time,
it comes carrying a spoon.
He has never been able to believe anything by halves.

Then a girl arrives, carrying a spoon.

She does not even feed him right away. She only sits close, and already he mistakes the proximity for devotion. By the time she offers the first mouthful, he has quietly rewritten the whole history of his hunger around her.

So this, he thinks, was the missing ingredient.

Not food.

Just another pair of hands.

He eats gladly.

He mistakes being fed for being chosen.

Only later does he understand she had never come to feed him at all.

She was only trying a recipe.

His hunger was the kitchen.

His gratitude, the tasting.

By the time she had tasted enough,

she no longer needed the table.

He remains where she found him—

still seated,

still hungry,

still wondering whether he imagined the taste.

Some hungers,

once learned,

never leave the body.

He keeps one old habit through all of it.

He inspects every crumb for its meaning, questions every misplaced grain, every small imperfection—and lets the larger meals of his life, the ones that quietly decide the shape of the years ahead, pass by untouched, as though deciding were a privilege reserved for someone wiser.

Every time a hand reaches toward him,
he forgets to ask the only question that ever mattered.

Who prepared this meal?

And before doubt has the chance to arrive,
he opens his mouth.

Every time.

After every famine,
he finds his way back to the table.

He straightens the plate.

He waits.

The table is set.

The spoon arrives.

And once again,
he opens his mouth.